- The matter was settled in the 1974 India-Sri Lanka Maritime Agreement, which drew a maritime boundary, with Katchatheevu in Sri Lankan waters
- However, Indian fishermen stray into Lankan waters regularly, resulting in their arrest by Lankan Navy, often straining ties
- Tamil Nadu believes the island to be an integral part of India. In 2013, the TN assembly passed a resolution seeking its retrieval
- The Indian establishment has always denied that Katchatheevu was 'ceded' to Lanka, stressed that retrieving it was 'impossible' and said it had no link with arrests of fishermen by the Lankan navy



thorn in India-Sri Lanka ties. Indian Tamil fishermen often cross the maritime boundary, cleaving to centuries-old practices to which they think they have a right. It is also a fact that fisheries on the Indian side are much depleted, and any attempt to grab a share of the rich Lankan fishing grounds has been fiercely resisted by Sri Lankan Tamils of the Jaffna area—who otherwise seek solidarity from their Indian brethren. The status of Katchatheevu has often been dragged into this larger issue by Tamil Nadu politicians and tied to the misery of poor fishermen. In fact, Tamil Nadu believes the island to be an integral part of India. In 2008, then TN chief minister J. Jayalalithaa cited old documents and filed a petition in the Supreme Court, challenging the legitimacy of the International Maritime Boundary Line (IMBL) between the two nations. In 2013, the Tamil Nadu assembly passed a resolution seeking the retrieval of Katchatheevu.

In a series of parliamentary replies, submissions to the Supreme Court and RTI responses, the Centre has held a consistent line: that Katchatheevu was not explicitly "ceded" to Sri Lanka in the maritime agreement; "retrieving" it was impossible; and the issue of Lankan authorities arresting Indian fishermen was not related to the island itself.

Katchatheevu island was born through volcanic activity, and is a prawn-rich fishing ground. It was controlled by the Jaffna kingdom of Sri Lanka in the early medieval period, but by the 17th century its control passed to the Ramnad zamindari based out of Ramanathapuram, and came under the Madras Presidency during the British Raj. However, both British India and Ceylon continued to claim their territorial authority over the island.

After the India-Pakistan war in 1971, when Lankan ports were used by Pakistan to refuel their warships, then Sri Lankan PM Bandaranaike took the initiative to resolve all outstanding maritime boundary disputes with New Delhi. India, too, complied, hoping to arrest China's moves to get access to Lanka. "In order to prevent Bandaranaike from going further towards Beijing, the Indian government agreed to give away Katchatheevu island and simultaneously started working towards the Wadge Bank agreement," says a key official in maritime security.

Former foreign secretary Nirupama Rao stated on X that the personal equation between Indira and Bandaranaike played a decisive role in the conclusion of the 1974 agreement. She also said India's moves on the matter must keep in mind the bilateral ties with Sri Lanka.

It is true that the 1976 pact with Lanka that gave India exclusive rights to Wadge Bank—with its natural gas reserves and fish-rich waters—was secured due to the satisfactory conclusion of the earlier pact. "Access to West Wadge Bank in the Gulf of Mannar is strategically important, as India can keep a check on the activities in Colombo port," says another Indian official.

A defence ministry official says that during the LTTE (Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam) years, as the Lankan navy was busy with its blockade of Jaffna, Indian fishermen enjoyed unrestricted fishing in Lankan waters. Once the LTTE was neutralised in 2009, Sri Lanka started focusing on Indian fishermen, routinely arresting them. In 2023, 240 Indian fishermen were arrested along with 35 trawlers for allegedly poaching in Lankan waters.

Kripa Nautiyal, former additional director general of the Indian Coast Guard, says, "Despite the agreement being in place for delineation of the IMBL between India and Sri Lanka, fishermen from both countries continue to breach it, which results in the apprehension of these boats by both the Indian Coast Guard and the Sri Lankan navy. Fortunately, there is a mechanism in place between the two countries to expedite the repatriation of these boats." Seasoned diplomats dismiss the current controversy as political chicanery and a storm in a fragile teacup. ■



"CONGRESS AND DMK'S CALLOUSNESS ON KATCHATHEEVU HAS HARMED THE INTERESTS OF OUR POOR FISHERMEN"

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister of India, on X